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7.5 Making Your Web Sites More Accessible with Microsoft FrontPage 2002 White Paper

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The Internet provides us with an easy way to publish and find information. However, information on the Internet is not always readily available to all users. Some people are unable to access the Internet through traditional Web browsers such as Microsoft Internet Explorer without the use of assistive technologies that enhance the way they interact with information. These assistive technologies, available from a wide range of third-party providers, include screen readers and Braille devices, audio browsers, screen magnifiers, text-only browsers, and voice input software. Other users, such as mobile professionals, are increasingly turning to alternative technologies to browse the Web, technologies such as cell phones and handheld computers with low-resolution displays. For each of these groups of users, it is important that a Web site provide alternatives.

Web programming today facilitates many types of non-text Web elements such as images, frames, applets, and tables. Yet most assistive technologies provide input to their users by interpreting text. What happens when an assistive device encounters a non-text element? In some cases, the device might stall. In other cases, the device simply provides no information about the element.

Today it is quite possible for Web developers to enable anyone to access the information on a Web page. When information on the Internet is accessible, everyone-including users of assistive and alternative technologies-can find and benefit from it.